

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Summer storms, NWS cuts put area on edge

Officials bracing after deadly Texas flooding and reductions to staff who warn of extreme weather

By William Tong, Daniel C. Vock and Paulina Czapryna
Chicago Tribune

When more than a month's worth of rain fell in 90 minutes just west of the United Center late Tuesday night, federal weather forecasters warned of possible flash flooding, triggering a chain of events that alerted some Chicago residents about potential danger.

Among them was Sandra Mason, 55, who lives in a ground-floor apartment on the Near West Side. After receiving an alert on her phone at 10 p.m. Tuesday, Mason began lining her back door with

blankets to stop any water from seeping in.

Just a few blocks east, the National Weather Service recorded 5 inches of rain falling in an hour and a half, as a thunderstorm stalled over downtown and nearby neighborhoods. The torrent inundated basements, flooded viaducts and closed expressway lanes. Emergency responders rescued stranded motorists.

Previous storms have flooded Mason's building, damaging appliances and furniture, but this time she was mostly spared. Still, she said she was grateful for the federal weather agency alerts.

"You don't know if your house is going to flood," Mason said. "You just don't know, you just have to be on your toes."

Weather-related anxiety is high across the country following flash floods in central Texas that killed at least 120 people over the Fourth of July weekend. One of the central concerns is whether Trump administration cuts to the National Weather Service — the backbone of the country's weather warning system — will hamper local governments and residents from staving off disaster when severe weather strikes.

The Trump administration this spring eliminated nearly 600 National Weather Service jobs across the country, through early

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Sheila Sutton stretches along the lakefront as a storm arrives on May 15 at Diversey Harbor in Chicago. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Children ride an e-bike together on North Walnut Street in Itasca on Thursday. Several communities — including Highland Park, Itasca, Schaumburg, Glen Ellyn and Lombard — have recently imposed restrictions on the use of e-bikes. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

In suburbs, a confusing patchwork of e-bike laws

Riders must learn age limits, path restrictions, rules that vary by vehicle class

By Paulina Czapryna
Chicago Tribune

Fifteen-year-old Sam Thomas has spent much of the past two years riding his e-bike between his Itasca home and nearby Elk Grove Village.

Too young to drive, the teen relishes the independence the battery-powered bicycle gives him as he moves between towns without needing a parent to chauffeur him. The bike easily can reach 30 mph, giving Sam a freedom that comes with some risks.

In addition to several curb falls and close calls, he was hit

by a car in June while riding in Elk Grove Village and sustained minor leg and wrist injuries. His bike sustained significant damage, but he was back on another one and riding between towns within a week.

The teen's journeys to Elk Grove Village, however, are no longer an option. As of July 1, anyone riding within town limits must have a valid driver's license to operate electric bikes and scooters.

The restriction means no one under 16 — including Sam and several of his friends — can ride on the streets there.

"I mainly bought (an e-bike) because it's easier to get places," Sam said. "I don't have to rely on my parents to take me to the gym, to play basketball or to my friend's house."

But what Sam appreciates as a convenience, Elk Grove Village officials see as a public safety issue.

"It's one thing for adults that know how to drive," Elk Grove Village Mayor Craig Johnson said in voicing his support for the new regulations last month. "It's a whole different thing when you get 11-, 12-, 13-year-olds going down a road with 3,000-pound cars driving next to them."

In passing the new rules, Elk Grove has joined a growing list of Chicago suburbs that have enacted tougher e-bike regulations due to growing safety concerns. Several communities — including Highland Park, Schaumburg, Glen Ellyn and Lombard — have recently imposed age limits on riders, while Burr Ridge has banned e-scooters from its streets.

Illinois law divides e-bikes into three classes based on their maximum assisted speed and whether the motor requires the rider to

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Father becomes face of lawsuit against ICE

Judge hears challenge to warrantless arrests

By Laura Rodríguez Presa and Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

Abel Orozco was getting home after buying tamales for his family, like he did most weekends for the past 30 years. They would have breakfast and head to church.

Instead, U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents detained the Mexican immigrant outside his home in suburban Lyons without a federal warrant. Now, nearly six months later, he is still detained.

Immigration and civil rights attorneys argue that his arrest was not only unfair but illegal. Thanks to the video his son recorded of the arrest, Orozco has become the face of a lawsuit against the U.S. Department of Homeland

Security and ICE. Attorneys say the two government agencies violated the constitutional rights of Orozco and at least 25 other people, including one U.S. citizen, during the first week of increased immigration enforcement in the Chicago area after President Donald Trump took office.

"I'm not used to (speaking in public), it's something that's really awkward for me and embarrassing," his son Eduardo Orozco told the Tribune. "But even though I

feel like that, I still have to do it for my father, and because there are many other people who are supporting us."

The father, 47, has a clean record. Yet he is the only plaintiff left that is still in detention. One was deported. The rest have been released.

"We are angry and concerned," his son said. "I hope the judge can see what we experienced on

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Questions remain after Pa. shooting

2024 Trump attack spurs 'wake-up call' for Secret Service

By Rebecca Santana
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — In many ways, the assassination attempt against Donald Trump at a Pennsylvania campaign stop was a perfect storm of failings coming together that allowed Michael Thomas Crooks to climb on top of a nearby building and take eight shots at the once and future president.

One attendee was killed, two others wounded and a bullet grazed Trump's ear July 13, 2024, before a Secret Service counter sniper opened fire on Crooks, 20, and killed him. That day jolted an already chaotic race for the White House and solidified Trump's iconic status in his party and beyond.

It also became a turning point for the agency tasked with protecting the president. As more details emerged about what went wrong, questions multiplied: What happened to the Secret Service's planning? Why was a rooftop with a clear line of sight to Trump left unguarded? What motivated the shooter?

A year after Butler, multiple investigations have detailed the breakdowns that day. Under a

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INSIDE



Suspect in officer's killing set for trial

Steven Montano will face a jury on charges of murder and other felonies in the fatal shooting of CPD Officer Andres Vásquez Lasso, who had responded to a domestic violence call. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Big bill shapes House control fight

President Donald Trump's sweeping budget-and-policy package is shaping the 2026 midterm battle for control of the House of Representatives. **Nation & World**

